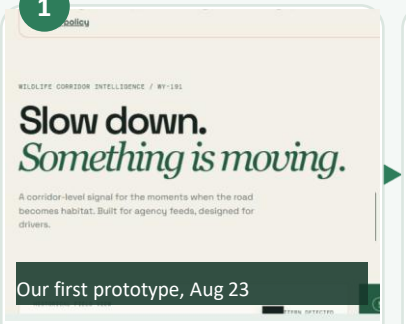
From a rough idea to a live app: how prompting works

Pause for Paws, built by The Blizzards #67350, a Waukee middle school student team

Now on the App Store!

iPhone: live now. Android: in testing.

1



Our first prototype, Aug 23

AUG 29

Start rough

WE ASKED

"Warn drivers when they near a road where animals cross."

WE GOT

A first map with 3 sample corridors and practice data.

2



The map on the phone

SEP 5 TO 7

Make it personal

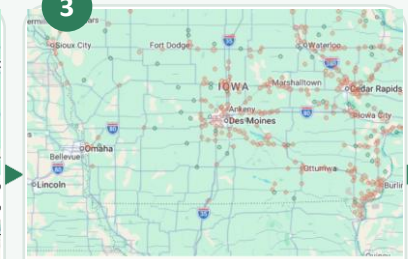
WE ASKED

"Put it on a phone and alert me when I am close."

WE GOT

An Android app, a location button, background alerts, a simpler map.

3



Real Iowa DOT crashes, live

SEP 12

Make it real

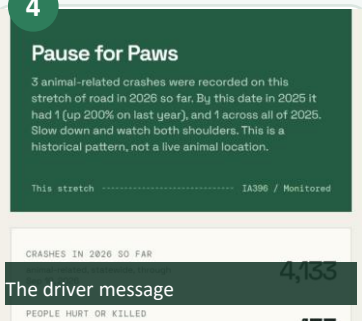
WE ASKED

"Use real crash data and put it online."

WE GOT

Iowa DOT data and a live website, pauseforpawsusa.org.

4



The driver message

SEP 14 TO 26

Listen and improve

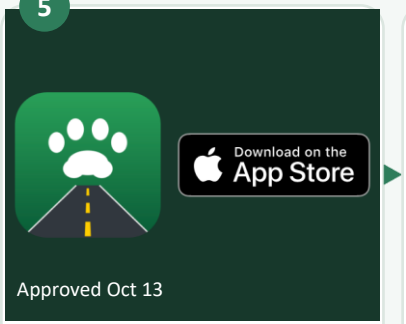
WE ASKED

"Make it useful, and fix what testers found."

WE GOT

ZIP search, year compare, voice alerts, an on/off switch, a fence cost tool.

5



Approved Oct 13

OCT 2 TO 13

Make it store-ready

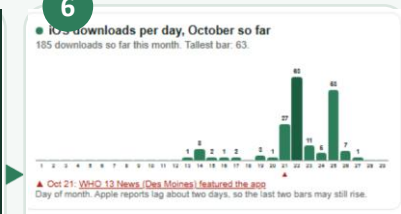
WE ASKED

"Add an icon, a privacy policy and store screenshots."

WE GOT

App Store approval on Oct 13 and a public iPhone app.

6



Daily downloads, WHO 13 flagged

OCT 21 ONWARD

Keep it true

WE ASKED

"Keep it accurate and show how it is doing."

WE GOT

WHO 13 News featured the app on Oct 21, and drivers keep downloading it.

Four prompt-engineering lessons from our journey

1. Start rough, then refine
One change per prompt. Each answer shows what to ask next.

2. Give context and limits
Who it is for, what data to use, and what we must not claim.

3. Test with real people
Testers asked for an on/off switch and a test alert, so we added them.

4. Check the AI's work
We found 152 repeated crash records and 22 phantom corridors, then asked for fixes.

Scan to get the free iPhone app

Data: Iowa DOT crash data